ISR Operations

Quick briefing

Separate intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance, then judge whether an ISR product answers the commander's question in time.

Know the facts

Intelligence · An assessment produced by combining and evaluating information from surveillance, reconnaissance, and other sources.

Surveillance · Sustained observation of an area, activity, or subject of interest.

Reconnaissance and assets · Reconnaissance collects data for a specific military question. The lesson groups ISR assets into airborne, ground-based, maritime, and space-based systems.

Coverage and persistence · Coverage describes what portion of the area or activity can be observed. Persistence describes how long observation can be maintained.

Fusion and interoperability · Fusion integrates observations from multiple sources. Interoperability lets different teams and systems exchange and use the resulting information.

Quality and safeguards · Timeliness, accuracy, and flexibility help keep information useful. Security and ethics guide collection, analysis, and sharing.

Understand the reasoning

A report can be accurate when collected and too old to support the current decision. Check what could have changed since observation.

Two summaries based on one observation share the same underlying evidence. Independent confirmation can add confidence when the decision warrants it.

Philippine Army classroom exercise

During a Philippine Army humanitarian assistance tabletop exercise, an older aerial image shows a road open, while a recent ground report says floodwater has reached it. The classroom staff must choose which route to include in a relief convoy briefing.

Decision · How should the staff reconcile the reports before recommending a route?

Worked analysis · Compare the observation times, confirm they refer to the same road segment, and seek a current authorized status update if time allows. The aerial image gives useful context, while the newer local report may better describe changing conditions. State the remaining uncertainty and give the staff a usable alternative if the road cannot be confirmed.

How to practice

1 · Write the decision question and the deadline for answering it.

2 · Compare source coverage, freshness, and ability to confirm the detail that matters.

3 · Cross-check conflicting reports against an independent source when available.

4 · State the assessed answer, its confidence limits, and who is authorized to receive it.

Check yourself

Which ISR component seeks an answer to a specific question? · Reconnaissance.

Why do timeliness and accuracy need to be assessed separately? · An accurate observation can arrive too late or become outdated, and a fast report can still be wrong.

Course source

Introduction to ISR Operations